

I4I Zacchaeus

A rich tax collector who climbed a tree to see Jesus and came down a changed man.

Zacchaeus was the chief tax collector in Jericho, and he was rich. People despised tax collectors as cheats who worked for Rome, and Zacchaeus was at the top of that trade. When Jesus passed through Jericho on his way to Jerusalem, Zacchaeus was too short to see over the crowd, so he ran ahead and climbed a sycamore tree. Jesus stopped, called him by name, and invited himself to his house. The crowd grumbled, but Zacchaeus stood up and promised to give half his goods to the poor and repay fourfold anyone he had cheated. Jesus said salvation had come to his house.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	From a Hebrew name usually explained as "pure"
<i>Job</i>	"Chief among the publicans," a senior tax collector (Luke 19:2)
<i>Wealth</i>	"He was rich" (Luke 19:2)
<i>Home</i>	Jericho
<i>When</i>	c. AD 30, days before Jesus' final Passover
<i>Known for</i>	Climbing a sycamore tree, and giving back what he had taken
<i>Main passages</i>	Luke 19:1–10
<i>New Testament</i>	Only in Luke

"For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost."

Luke 19:10, KJV

The life of Zacchaeus

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Luke sets the story on Jesus' last journey up to Jerusalem (Luke 19:11, 28).

c. AD 30

Jericho

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Tries to see Jesus

Jesus passes through Jericho. Zacchaeus wants to see who Jesus is but cannot because of the crowd, for he is "little of stature." He runs ahead and climbs a sycamore tree. *Luke 19:1-4*

The same day

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Called by name

At the tree Jesus looks up: "Zacchaeus, make haste, and come down; for to day I must abide at thy house." Zacchaeus hurries down and receives him joyfully. *Luke 19:5-6*

The same day

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The crowd murmurs

Everyone who sees it complains that Jesus has gone "to be guest with a man that is a sinner." To them, a chief tax collector is beyond the pale. *Luke 19:7*

At his house

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A changed man

Zacchaeus stands and promises half his goods to the poor and fourfold repayment to anyone he has cheated. Jesus says, "This day is salvation come to this house." *Luke 19:8-10*

Group notes

Key activities

Zacchaeus's words in Luke 19:8 can be read two ways. Most take them as a promise of change from that day. Some read them as a description of what he already did, defending himself against the crowd. Either way, Jesus declares that salvation has come.

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- 1 Sought Jesus.** He wanted to see who Jesus was, and he did not let the crowd stop him. *Luke 19:3*

 - 2 Climbed a tree.** He ran ahead and climbed a sycomore, setting aside his dignity to catch a glimpse. *Luke 19:4*

 - 3 Welcomed Jesus joyfully.** He came down at once and received Jesus into his home. *Luke 19:6*

 - 4 Gave to the poor.** He pledged half of his goods to the poor. *Luke 19:8*

 - 5 Promised to repay fourfold.** He offered to restore four times over anything taken by false accusation, far more than the law usually required. *Luke 19:8; Numbers 5:7*

 - 6 Heard a new name.** Jesus called him "a son of Abraham," a true member of God's people. *Luke 19:9*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Zacchaeus.

Old Testament

Exodus 22:1; 2 Samuel 12:6	Fourfold repayment, the measure Zacchaeus chose
Leviticus 6:1–5; Numbers 5:6–7	The usual repayment: the full amount plus a fifth
Echo: Ezekiel 34:16	"I will seek that which was lost"

New Testament

Luke 19:1–10	The only account
Luke 3:12–13	John tells tax collectors to exact no more than appointed
Luke 5:27–32; 15:1–2	Jesus eats with tax collectors and sinners
Echo: Matthew 9:9	Matthew, another tax collector, follows Jesus
Echo: Luke 15	The lost sheep, coin and son are found

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Zacchaeus do to see Jesus, and what did Jesus say to him (Luke 19:3–5)?
2. *Understand:* Why did the crowd murmur, and how does Luke 19:10 answer them?
3. *Apply:* Zacchaeus made things right with what he had wrongly taken. Is there something you need to set right with someone this week?
4. *Apply:* Who in your community is treated like Zacchaeus, and how could you welcome them?